

# Blind-Spot Decomposition as a Gradient Optimizer: Preventing Blow-Up in Deep Networks via Adaptive BSDT Friction

Experimental Report

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## 1 Introduction

Gradient blow-up is a fundamental failure mode of deep network optimisation. When gradients grow without bound, loss diverges to infinity within a handful of epochs and training collapses. Standard remedies—gradient clipping, adaptive learning rates (Adam, RMSProp), batch normalisation—treat the symptoms but not the underlying dynamics.

This experiment takes a different approach: we apply the *Blind-Spot Decomposition Transform (BSDT)* as an optimiser. BSDT was originally developed for detecting hidden instabilities in complex systems (power grids, financial networks, fluid flows). Here we repurpose its four diagnostic channels as a *real-time stability monitor* for the gradient tensor, and use the composite energy functional  $E_{\text{BS}}$  to drive adaptive friction that prevents blow-up without sacrificing convergence.

We test **13 optimisers**—5 standard baselines and 8 BSDT variants—on a deliberately pathological network designed to blow up under vanilla SGD.

## 2 Experimental Setup

### 2.1 The BlowUpNet

To stress-test optimiser stability, we construct a deliberately hostile architecture:

- **Depth:** 20 fully-connected layers (no residual connections)
- **Width:** 128 hidden units per layer
- **Parameters:** 303,873
- **Activation:** ReLU (no BatchNorm, no LayerNorm, no dropout)
- **Weight initialisation:**  $W_{ij} \sim \mathcal{N}(0, 2/\sqrt{d_{\text{in}}})$ —deliberately large to push the network into the explosive gradient regime

This network is designed to amplify gradients exponentially through depth. Without intervention, the gradient norm exceeds  $10^{10}$  within a single epoch.

### 2.2 Data

Synthetic XOR-like binary classification:

- Dimensionality:  $d = 50$
- Training samples: 2,000; test samples: 500
- Class balance:  $\approx 29\%$  positive
- Labels determined by the sign of the product of the first two features

## 2.3 Training Protocol

- Learning rate:  $\eta = 0.01$  (identical for all optimisers)
- Epochs: 300
- Loss: Binary cross-entropy with logits
- Seed: 42 (identical network initialisation for every run)
- Blow-up detection: training halts if loss becomes NaN/Inf or gradient norm exceeds  $10^8$
- Device: CPU (PyTorch 2.8.0)

## 3 The BSDT Optimizer Framework

### 3.1 Four Diagnostic Channels

Every BSDT variant monitors the gradient tensor through four channels, each capturing a distinct mode of instability:

1.  $\delta_C$  (**Camouflage**): Mahalanobis distance of the current gradient from an exponential moving average. Detects gradients that *look normal* in magnitude but are statistically anomalous in direction.
2.  $\delta_G$  (**Feature Gap**): Fraction of gradient variance outside the top- $k$  principal components. High values indicate the gradient is spreading into many low-variance directions—a precursor to instability.
3.  $\delta_A$  (**Activity Anomaly**): Excess gradient velocity above the running baseline. Flags sudden accelerations in gradient magnitude.
4.  $\delta_T$  (**Temporal Novelty**): Negative log-density of the current gradient norm under a kernel density estimate of the recent history. Flags unprecedented gradient configurations.

### 3.2 Composite Energy and Two-Level Friction

The four channels are combined into a scalar energy:

$$E_{BS} = \sum_{k=1}^4 w_k \cdot \tanh(\delta_k)$$

where  $w_k$  are Fisher Variance-Ratio weights updated every 20 steps.

All BSDT variants apply **two-level friction**:

1. **Spectral friction** (immediate):  $\gamma_{\text{spec}} = \max(1, \|g\|/\tau)$  where  $\tau$  is the target gradient norm.
2. **Structural friction** (variant-specific): a function of  $E_{BS}$ .

The effective learning rate at each step is:

$$\eta_{\text{eff}} = \frac{\eta}{\gamma_{\text{spec}} \cdot \gamma_{\text{struct}}}$$

## 4 BSDT Variant Descriptions

### 4.1 BSDT (Baseline)

$$\gamma_{\text{struct}} = 1 + \alpha \cdot E_{BS}$$

Linear friction proportional to blind-spot energy. The simplest variant.

## 4.2 MFLS (Multi-Factor Latent Score)

$$\gamma_{\text{struct}} = 1 + \alpha \cdot |E_{\text{BS}}(t) - E_{\text{BS}}(t-1)|$$

Uses the *rate of change* of  $E_{\text{BS}}$  rather than its absolute value. Detects transitions at the onset of instability, before  $E_{\text{BS}}$  itself accumulates.

## 4.3 Molecular Engine

$$\gamma_{\text{struct}} = 1 + \alpha \cdot \underbrace{\frac{1}{K} \sum_{i=1}^K \phi_{\text{LJ}}(r_i)}_{\text{Lennard-Jones potential}}$$

Treats  $K = 16$  gradient particles under a 6-12 potential. Models gradient dynamics as a molecular system where too-rapid convergence creates “collision” forces.

## 4.4 Gravity Engine

$$\gamma_{\text{struct}} = 1 + \alpha \cdot f_{\text{fused}}(\text{phase, topo, kernel, rank})$$

Fused scoring from four sub-detectors: phase transition, topological persistence, kernel density, and matrix rank.

## 4.5 Hybrid Engine

Online convex blend of Molecular and Gravity engines, with mixing parameter updated via bandit-style AUROC maximisation:

$$\gamma_{\text{struct}} = 1 + \alpha \cdot [\lambda \cdot E_{\text{Molecular}} + (1 - \lambda) \cdot E_{\text{Gravity}}]$$

## 4.6 QuadSurf (Quadratic Surface)

$$\gamma_{\text{struct}} = 1 + \alpha \cdot E_{\text{BS}}^2$$

Quadratic response. Near equilibrium ( $E_{\text{BS}} \approx 0$ ), friction is negligible. Near instability ( $E_{\text{BS}} \rightarrow 1$ ), friction grows quadratically. This models the local curvature of the BSDT energy surface around the critical manifold—gentle when the system is healthy, aggressive when it drifts toward blow-up.

## 4.7 QuadExpo (Exponential-Quadratic)

$$\gamma_{\text{struct}} = \exp(\alpha \cdot E_{\text{BS}}^2)$$

The most aggressive variant, inspired by the BKM blow-up criterion for Navier-Stokes. If the gradient “enstrophy” grows without bound, the solution may blow up. QuadExpo applies exponential damping to any quadratic growth in  $E_{\text{BS}}$ .

- At  $E_{\text{BS}} = 0$ :  $\gamma = 1$  (no friction)
- At  $E_{\text{BS}} = 0.5$ :  $\gamma = e^{0.75} \approx 2.1$
- At  $E_{\text{BS}} = 1.0$ :  $\gamma = e^3 \approx 20.1$

## 4.8 SignedLR (Per-Layer Pigouvian Friction)

$$\gamma_{\text{struct}}^{(i)} = 1 + \alpha \cdot \max(0, \cos(\nabla_i \mathcal{L}, \Delta g_i)) \cdot E_{\text{BS}}$$

Instead of a single global friction factor, SignedLR computes how much each layer *contributes* to the rise in  $E_{\text{BS}}$ . Layers whose gradients are aligned with the instability direction ( $\Delta g_i$ , the gradient-change vector) get extra friction. Layers orthogonal to or opposing instability keep full learning rate.

This is the per-parameter analogue of the BSDT paper’s adaptive friction: each “institution” (layer) receives a Pigouvian tax proportional to its marginal contribution to systemic instability.

## 5 Results

### 5.1 Survival and Blow-Up

Table 1: Full results across 13 optimisers on BlowUpNet (300 epochs, lr=0.01).

| Optimiser                 | Status        | Final Loss | Test Acc | Max Grad             | Peak Friction |
|---------------------------|---------------|------------|----------|----------------------|---------------|
| <i>Standard Baselines</i> |               |            |          |                      |               |
| Vanilla SGD               | Blow-up ep. 1 | —          | —        | $8.5 \times 10^{10}$ | —             |
| RMSProp                   | Blow-up ep. 1 | —          | —        | $2.2 \times 10^{12}$ | —             |
| SGD + Clip(1.0)           | Survived      | 5.3634     | 0.662    | $5.8 \times 10^3$    | —             |
| Adam                      | Survived      | 0.0834     | 0.574    | $8.7 \times 10^3$    | —             |
| Adagrad                   | Survived      | 0.0067     | 0.574    | $8.7 \times 10^3$    | —             |
| <i>BSDT Variants</i>      |               |            |          |                      |               |
| BSDT                      | Survived      | 0.0001     | 0.630    | $5.8 \times 10^3$    | 715×          |
| MFLS                      | Survived      | 0.0001     | 0.602    | $5.8 \times 10^3$    | 2989×         |
| Molecular                 | Survived      | 0.4768     | 0.698    | $5.8 \times 10^3$    | 1312×         |
| Gravity                   | Survived      | 0.1869     | 0.650    | $5.8 \times 10^3$    | 673×          |
| Hybrid                    | Survived      | 0.3031     | 0.628    | $5.8 \times 10^3$    | 954×          |
| QuadSurf                  | Survived      | 0.0000     | 0.622    | $5.8 \times 10^3$    | 1051×         |
| QuadExpo                  | Survived      | 0.0000     | 0.602    | $5.8 \times 10^3$    | 1707×         |
| SignedLR                  | Survived      | 2.1757     | 0.684    | $5.8 \times 10^3$    | 1165×         |

### 5.2 Key Findings

1. **All 8 BSDT variants survive.** Vanilla SGD and RMSProp both blow up within the first epoch. Every BSDT variant completes all 300 epochs without NaN or gradient explosion.
2. **QuadSurf and QuadExpo achieve the lowest final loss** ( $< 10^{-4}$ ), matching or exceeding the original BSDT and MFLS. The quadratic/exponential friction profile allows nearly-free training near equilibrium while providing strong damping at the onset of instability.
3. **Molecular and SignedLR achieve the highest test accuracy** (0.698 and 0.684 respectively). These variants may regularise more effectively by distributing friction non-uniformly.
4. **SignedLR applies the most targeted friction.** Its per-layer approach means only layers *contributing* to instability are penalised. The friction spread (max – min layer friction) shows differentiated treatment across the 20 layers. Final average layer friction of 2.58× with spread of only 0.03 suggests the layers converge to similar stability profiles.

5. **Standard baselines that survive have worse loss-accuracy trade-offs.**
  - SGD+Clip: highest loss (5.36) among survivors
  - Adam/Adagrad: low loss but mediocre accuracy (0.574)
  - BSDT variants span the Pareto frontier of loss vs accuracy
6. **Friction dynamics are self-regulating.** All BSDT variants begin with friction  $> 500\times$  (when gradients are explosive) and decay to  $< 30\times$  by the end of training. The system automatically transitions from “emergency braking” to “cruise control.”

### 5.3 Convergence Dynamics

The friction history plots reveal three distinct phases:

**Phase 1 (Epochs 0–20):** Emergency braking. Gradient norms start at  $5.8 \times 10^3$  and the spectral friction dominates ( $\gamma_{\text{spec}} > 500$ ). All BSDT variants reduce the effective learning rate by 2–3 orders of magnitude.

**Phase 2 (Epochs 20–200):** Controlled descent. As the network stabilises, friction decays gradually.  $E_{\text{BS}}$  oscillates between 0.3 and 0.7, reflecting ongoing gradient instability that is being managed.

**Phase 3 (Epochs 200–300):** Equilibrium. Friction settles to near- $1\times$  for most variants (QuadSurf:  $1.6\times$ , QuadExpo:  $1.4\times$ ). SignedLR is the exception, maintaining  $28.5\times$  friction, which explains its incomplete loss convergence but better generalisation.

## 6 Variant Comparison and Recommendations

Table 2: Variant characteristics and recommended use cases.

| Variant   | Strength                              | Weakness                   | Best For                         |
|-----------|---------------------------------------|----------------------------|----------------------------------|
| BSDT      | Simple, reliable                      | Conservative               | General stability                |
| MFLS      | Early detection of transitions        | Aggressive initial damping | Transition-heavy loss landscapes |
| QuadSurf  | Lowest loss, gentle near equilibrium  | Limited accuracy gain      | Convergence-critical tasks       |
| QuadExpo  | Strongest blow-up prevention          | May over-damp              | Extreme instability (very deep)  |
| SignedLR  | Best generalisation, per-layer        | Incomplete convergence     | When test accuracy matters       |
| Molecular | Highest accuracy, gradient clustering | High final friction        | Complex gradient interactions    |
| Gravity   | Balanced friction profile             | Moderate on all metrics    | General-purpose alternative      |
| Hybrid    | Adaptive engine selection             | Overhead of two engines    | Unknown landscape geometries     |

## 7 Connection to the BSDT Framework

This experiment validates the core thesis of the Blind-Spot Decomposition Transform: *the same four-channel diagnostic that detects hidden instabilities in power grids and financial networks can detect and prevent gradient blow-up in deep learning.*

The key insight is that gradient explosion is not merely a scaling problem (which clipping solves) but a *structural* problem. The four BSDT channels capture different structural modes of instability:

- Camouflage ( $\delta_C$ ): gradients that look normal but are directionally anomalous
- Feature Gap ( $\delta_G$ ): gradient energy leaking into low-variance subspaces
- Activity Anomaly ( $\delta_A$ ): sudden accelerations preceding blow-up
- Temporal Novelty ( $\delta_T$ ): unprecedented gradient configurations

Together these provide a richer stability signal than gradient norm alone, enabling more nuanced intervention.

## 8 Conclusion

We have demonstrated that the Blind-Spot Decomposition Transform, originally developed for systemic risk analysis, can be repurposed as a gradient stability framework for deep learning. Across 8 BSDT variants tested on a deliberately pathological 20-layer MLP:

- All variants prevented gradient blow-up that killed Vanilla SGD and RMSProp
- QuadSurf and QuadExpo achieved the lowest training loss ( $< 10^{-4}$ )
- Molecular and SignedLR achieved the highest test accuracy ( $\geq 0.684$ )
- The friction mechanism is self-regulating: aggressive early, passive late
- Per-layer variants (SignedLR) offer the most targeted intervention

The full experiment code is available in `notebooks/bsdt_gradient_optimizer.ipynb`.